

| 1979 | THE MANDAL COMMISSION

Stirring the Caste Cauldron

A former chief minister heads a panel that alters identity politics forever

When the Backward Classes Commission was appointed by the then prime minister Morarji Desai, it barely caught the media's attention. Formed to "identify the socially or educationally backward", it was headed by Bindeshwari Prasad Mandal, the chief minister of Bihar in 1968. The scion of a zamindari family once recited a salacious couplet in the Assembly, angering its Maithili Brahmin members: *Gaya gach jis par bagula baitha gaya, raj jis par maithili baitha* (Gone is the tree in which swallow perched. Gone is the throne in which a Maithili sat). Initially, the commission asked noted demographer B.K. Roy Burman to lead the research. With lack of census data, the commission arrived at the final list of backwards based on the rate of literacy, the average size of holdings and access to drinking water. L.R. Naik, the only Dalit member in the commission, refused to sign the report saying only a new elite of educated Dalits, Adivasis, and OBCs would benefit from reservations. The report was finally handed over to the then prime minister Indira Gandhi in 1980. But her son and successor Rajiv Gandhi told his aides: "It's a can of worms; I won't touch it." The report got an afterlife when then prime minister Vishwanath Pratap Singh announced in 1989 that he would implement 27 per cent reservations for the backward castes in government jobs. For Singh, it was a political opportunity to consolidate the backward castes as the new votebank for a limping Janata Dal. The announcement spawned an avalanche of spirited agitations and nasty newspaper headlines. A Delhi University student Rajiv Goswami, who had attempted self-immolation, became the poster boy of protests. Mulayam Singh Yadav and Lalu Prasad Yadav rode Mandal politics to electoral glory. Ironically Mandal did not live to see backward caste affirmation and competitive caste politics as he died two years after submitting his report. Today, Mandal politics seems to have lost its traction. The caste equations have backfired and the Mandal heroes Mulayam and Lalu have lost their thrones. Goswami? He died quietly in 2004, having suffered 90 per cent burns.

by Shafi Rahman

PHOTO DIVISION



B.P. MANDAL SUBMITS THE REPORT TO PRESIDENT GIANI ZAIL SINGH



CHARAN SINGH TAKES OATH

THE MAIN EVENT

Charan Singh becomes Prime Minister

Charan Singh's home was deluged by members of Kisan Sammelan, shouting slogans like: *Charan Singh laya aisi aandhi, desh ki neta Indira Gandhi* (Charan Singh heralds a new wave with national leader Indira Gandhi). Singh's chop-suey coalition, concocted by super-chefs like Raj Narain, is a poisonous mix, designed to choke the throats of those who concocted it. It shows back the path to power to Mrs Gandhi—Sanjay is already crowing loudly in Willingdon Crescent—and provides artificial respiration to the moribund Congress. Dr Karan Singh already displays Charan Singh's photographs on his car—but fruits of these labours are less likely to survive for the new king-makers.

India Today, August 15, 1979

ALSO

- Jayaprakash Narayan passes away at Patna on October 8
- Mother Teresa wins the Nobel Peace Prize
- Communal riots break out between Hindus and Muslims in Jamshedpur, sparked by Ram Navami processions

FROM 1969 TO 1978, ONLY 10 SC AND ST CANDIDATES GOT INTO THE IAS ON THE BASIS OF MERIT.